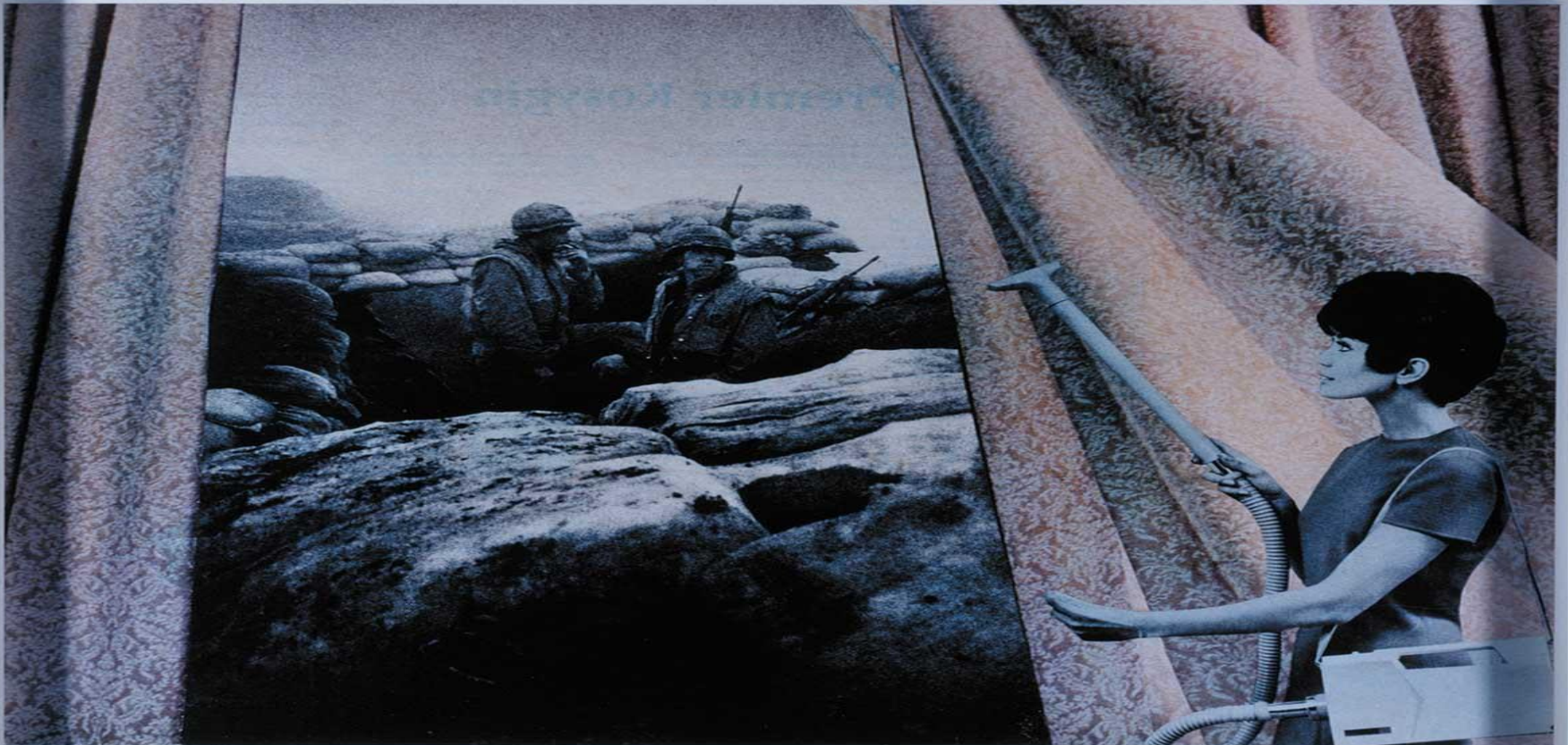


CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY

SC 301-3-FY

Michael Halewood

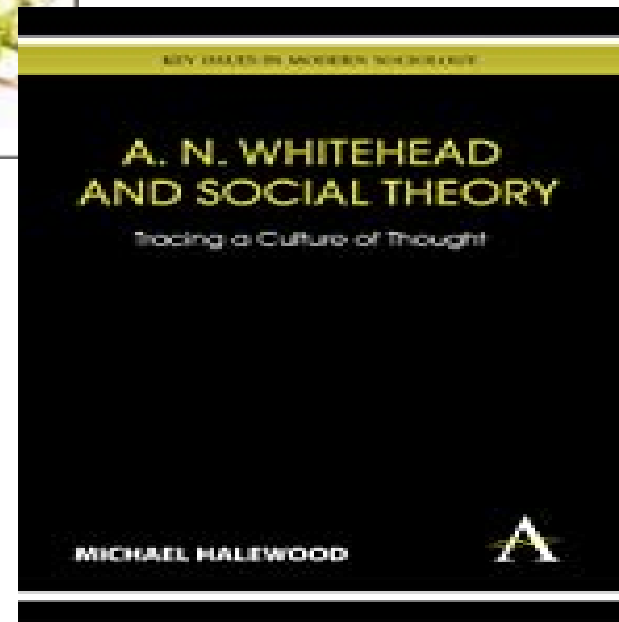
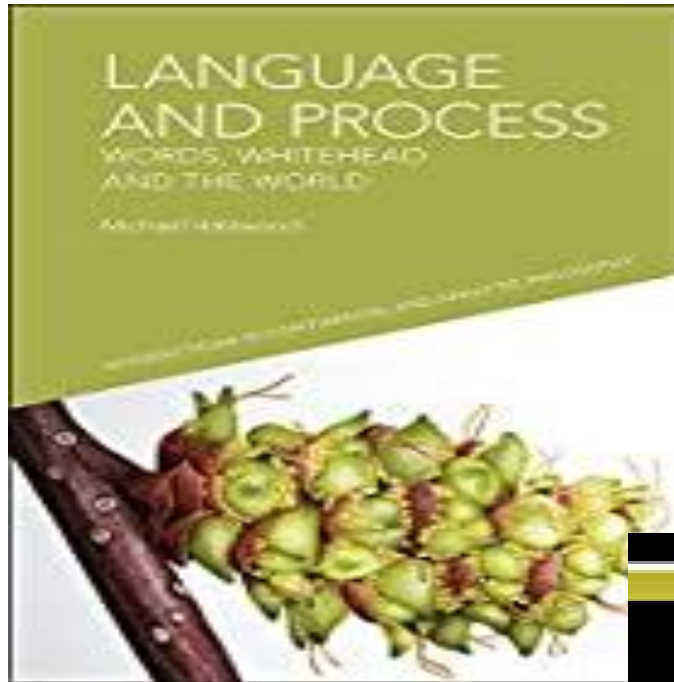


Who am I?

- Professor Michael Halewood
- Email: m.halewood@essex.ac.uk
- Office Hours: Tuesday – 12-1
- Room 6.354
- Or email for an appointment

What do I do?

- I teach and I research
- Here are some of my books:



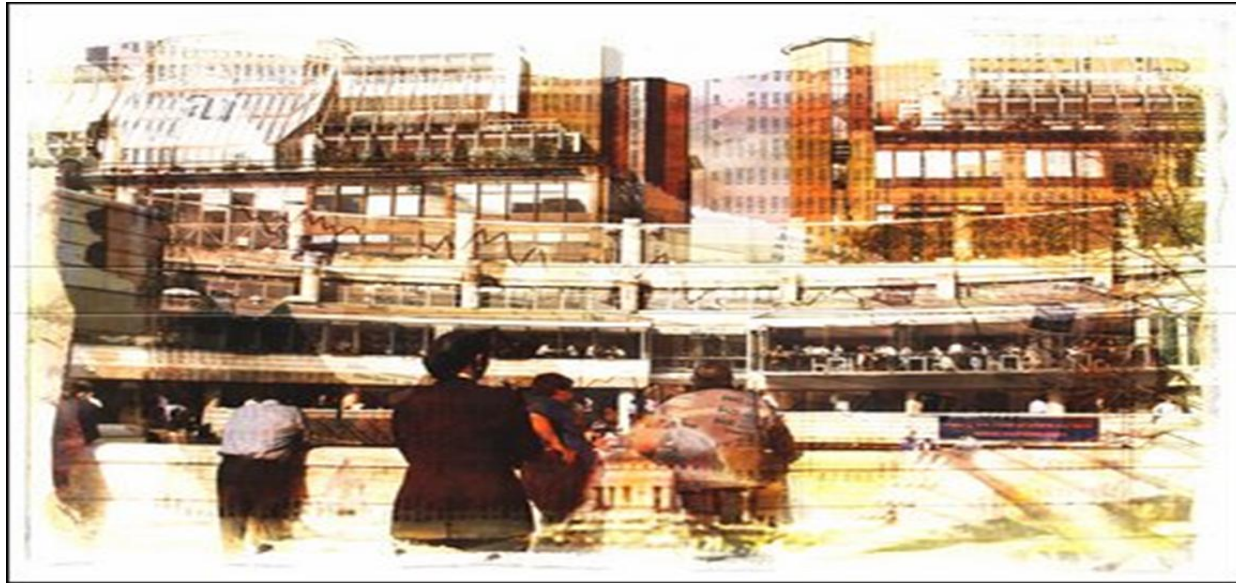
Autumn Term Lectures:

- Topic 1 - week 2 – Rethinking Modernity (Introducing theory and the module)
- Topic 2 - week 3 – Is Modernity a Colonial Project?
- Topic 3 - week 4 – Animals, Society and Modernity
- Topic 4 - week 5 – Language and the World
- Topic 5 - week 6 – A Question of Experience? Feminism and Social Theory
- Topic 6 - week 7 - Standpoint, Perspectives and Epistemology
- Topic 7 - week 8 – Foucault on Power and Disciplinary Society
- Topic 8 - week 9 – A Question of Experience? “Race” and Social Theory
- Topic 9 - week 10 – Post-Colonial Theory
- Topic 10 - week 11 – Ways of Seeing. Vision, Knowledge and Power

Spring Term

- Topic 11 - week 16 - The Mass Society and Mass Culture Debate
- Topic 12 - week 17 - Marx, Ideology and the Frankfurt School
- Topic 13 - week 18 - Habermas and the Public Sphere
- Topic 14 - week 19 - Culture is Ordinary
- Topic 15 - week 20 - Structuralism and Cultural Signs
- Reading Week - week 21
- Topic 16 - week 22 - Postmodernism
- Topic 17 - week 23 - The Turn to Gramsci and Hegemony
- Topic 18 - week 24 - Foucault and Cultural Governance
- Topic 19 - week 25 - Feminist Media Theory

What do we expect of you?



- We don't expect you to understand everything!
- But you should try to develop a position or stance with regard to some of the topics that we cover.
- For your coursework you need to write an essay, but one which develops an argument!..
- This applies to the exam as well.

ASSESSMENT (COURSEWORK)

- We want to know what you think about the material that we have covered.
- This means that we want to develop your own position or argument in your coursework.
- We don't just want you to summarise what other people have said (though some of that will be needed)
- We want you to say why what they say matters. Or doesn't matter. Or is wrong and could be improved.

Assessment (continued)

- At the very start of your essay, we want you to start with a short paragraph of no more than 250 words which sets out two things:
 - 1) Why you chose to do this essay
 - 2) One thing you learned from the lecture, the class or the reading for this topic.
- This short paragraph could be quite “informal” or at least not overly academic. For example: *“I chose to do this essay because ever since I started learning about sociology, people have been using the word “modernity” but they never really explained what it meant. The main thing I learned from this topic is that Europeans were trading in slaves and gold with South America much earlier than I realised (from the early 1500s). I found it interesting to learn about the role of sugar in the development of slavery. All this made me think differently about modernity and how it developed.”*

The First Autumn Term Question

- Using quotations from the material by Howard French and/or Enrique Dussel (as posted on Talis for Weeks 1, 2) set out your response to the question – “Is Modernity a Colonial Project”. Make sure to use examples and material from the lecture and class to support your argument.
-
- Remember to start to start with a short paragraph of 250 words which sets out:
- Why you chose to do this essay
- One thing you learned from the lecture, the class or the reading for this topic and why you found that interesting.
-



And the second...

- **Using quotations from Carter and Charles' 2016/2018 article (as posted on Talis – and NOT their 2013 article on Animals, Agency and Resistance) as well as the material and ideas discussed in the lecture, set out your understanding of the challenge that animals pose for Sociology.**
-
- Remember to start to start with a short paragraph of 250 words which sets out:
- Why you chose to do this essay
- One thing you learned from the lecture, the class or the reading for this topic and why you found that interesting.
-



And for Week 4

- Using material from the powerpoint slides for Lecture 4 and using quotations from Chapter 7 of Halewood's book *Language and Process*, set out your understanding of the link between language and power in terms of either gender or ethnicity.
- Remember to start to start with a short paragraph of 250 words which sets out:
- Why you chose to do this essay
- One thing you learned from the lecture, the class or the reading for this topic and why you found that interesting.
-



Safe Zones

Part 2 – Imagination and Analysis



Imagination

- In first year we introduced you to the “Sociological Imagination”, perhaps in a historical kind of way. For example:
- Simone de Beauvoir tried to understand the role and status of “woman” and “women” in the 20th century.
- To do so, she imagined what the world and social theory would look like if it took women seriously.
- But this “sociological imagination” is not just historical!
- It is something we can still do – We need to use our imagination
- For example to think about what the world would (or could) be like if we thought and acted differently.

More on Imagination

- This year, in this module, and in your projects, we will ask you to use your own imagination to develop your own arguments/perspectives/theories.
- When presented with a situation or event or problem, what is needed is some imagination to experiment with thinking about these.
- We sit back and picture how we can best link the ideas and facts we are presented with
- And provide a more accurate, more robust understanding of the world.

Imagination and Thinking

- This module is a social theory module.
- I think theory is really exciting
- It allows you to think.
- To try out different ways of looking at the world.
- This, again, involves imagination. An active imagination.
- And is tied up with how we “see” the world...

- A Portugese map from 1502



It is, in fact, something called the Cantino Planisphere

- It is remarkable as it focuses not on land masses and cities but on coasts and oceans and links between countries:
- The following link has lots of more detailed images. But its interpretation of these only briefly mentions slavery and does not seem to notice that West Africa had enormous resources:
- <https://smarthistory.org/cantino-planisphere/>

Sugar

- The birth of the sugar trade in the 1500s produced more “wealth” than the silver and gold that was discovered in West Africa and later by the Spanish in Mexico, Central and South America
- Sugar was where the idea of a plantation and plantation slavery started.
- In Madeira
- And Sao Tome and Principe (islands near Africa).
- Sugar, modernity and slavery....

Rethinking the Canon (the “Founding Fathers”)

- Last year in SC 201, you were encouraged to think about the origins of social theory – who was included and who was missed out
- What would sociology be like if we actually had taken Du Bois (not just Marx) seriously all along.
- For example:-

In 1915, Du Bois wrote this – asking us to Rethink Modernity...

- ‘For four hundred years, from 1450 to 1850, European civilization carried on a systematic trade in human beings of such tremendous proportions that the physical, economic and moral effects are still plainly to be remarked throughout the world. [...] These were not days of decadence, but a period that gave the world Shakespeare, Martin Luther, and Raphael, Haroun-al-Raschid and Abraham Lincoln. It was the day of the greatest expansion of two of the world’s most pretentious religions and of the beginnings of the modern organization of industry. In the midst of this advance and uplift this slave trade and slavery spread more human misery, inculcated more disrespect for and neglect of humanity, a greater callousness to suffering, and more petty, cruel, human hatred than can well be calculated. We may excuse and palliate it, and write history so as to let men forget it; it remains the most inexcusable and despicable blot on modern human history.’
Du Bois: 1970 [1915] : 89- 90

The key reading for this week is a summary of....

Born in Blackness. Africa, Africans and the Making of the Modern World, 1471 to the Second World War

By Howard French (2021)

He argues that we must not ignore the role of Africa in the development of modernity

The point is not simply to “add” Africa in but to change, to add to, to invert the current view

To see another perspective among many

For example, the Portuguese use cotton from India to buy gold in Africa to use as coinage in Europe (in the 1500s!)

Some more things to think about

- By the 1490s, Portugal was shipping nearly 600 kilos of gold a year from West Africa (French, 2021: 288)
- And also enslaved people to Europe and soon to Brazil
- No later than 1629, enslaved people from Central Africa were in Bolivia and Peru (a Kimbundu-Spanish grammar was published (Kimbundu is a Central African Language) (French, 2021: 288)
- 40% of ALL people enslaved on plantations went from Africa to Brazil (French, 2021: 177)

So,

- We need to look at think about the how the West thought about other peoples of the world. And how it acted towards them.
- As Marx puts:
- **“Without slavery you have no cotton; without cotton you have no modern industry. It is slavery that gave the colonies their value; it is the colonies that created world trade and it is world trade that is the pre-condition of large-scale industry.”** (Marx, 1977: 203 - *Karl Marx – Selected Writings* (ed. McLellan), Oxford University Press.

Critique as pointing to the future?

- When we critique contemporary society in terms of class, ethnicity, gender, etc. – are we pointing to how things could change?
- Marx:
- **“The philosophers have only interpreted the world, in various ways; the point is to change it.” (Marx: 1977: 158, Theses on Feurbach)**

Is Sociology only “Critical”?

- For the last 3 years, we have taught you to be critical.
- Did we actually mean “critique”?
- “Criticise” means to say what is wrong – to find fault
- “Critique” means to...
- Evaluate the structure
- See what works well
- Suggest clarifications
- Suggest improvements
- (Remember this for your essays and exam)

Analysis

- You are now 3rd /Final years.
- You will be expected to write better essays than in 2nd year.
- But don't worry – look at your 1st year essays and compare them with your last essay.
- This year, try and focus on analysis....

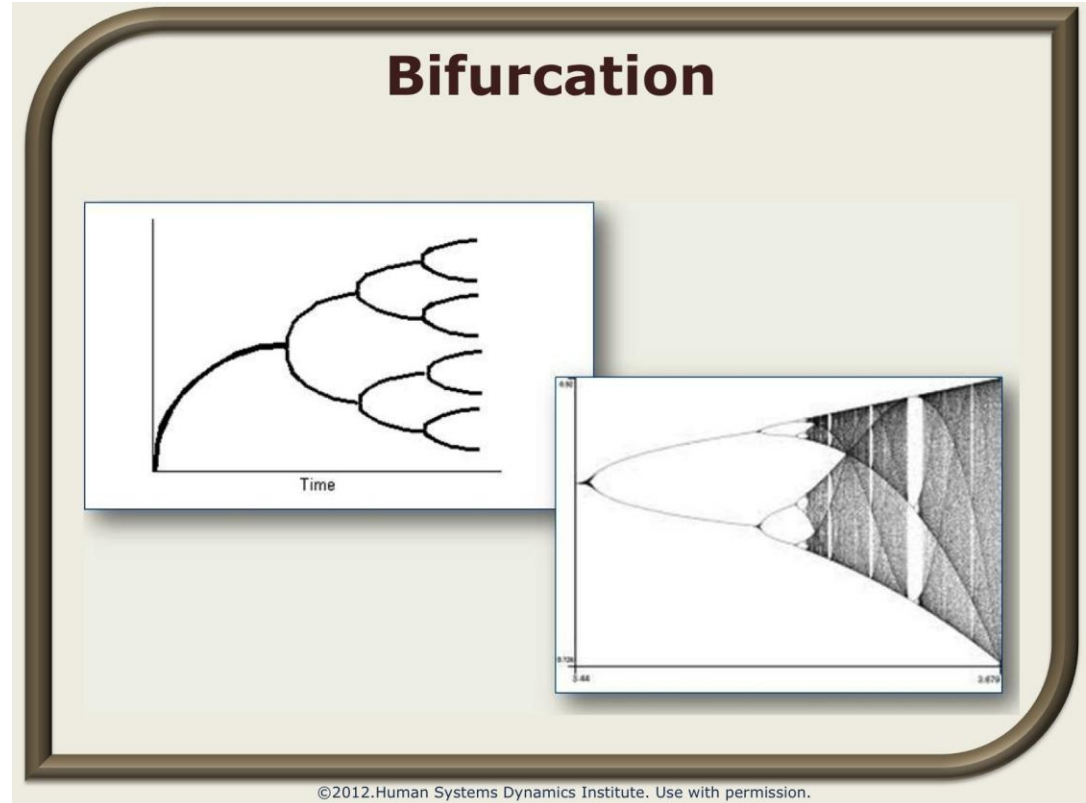
Part 3: Bifurcation and Modernity

The Problem of Bifurcation

Bifurcation refers to the splitting of something into 2 branches or routes.

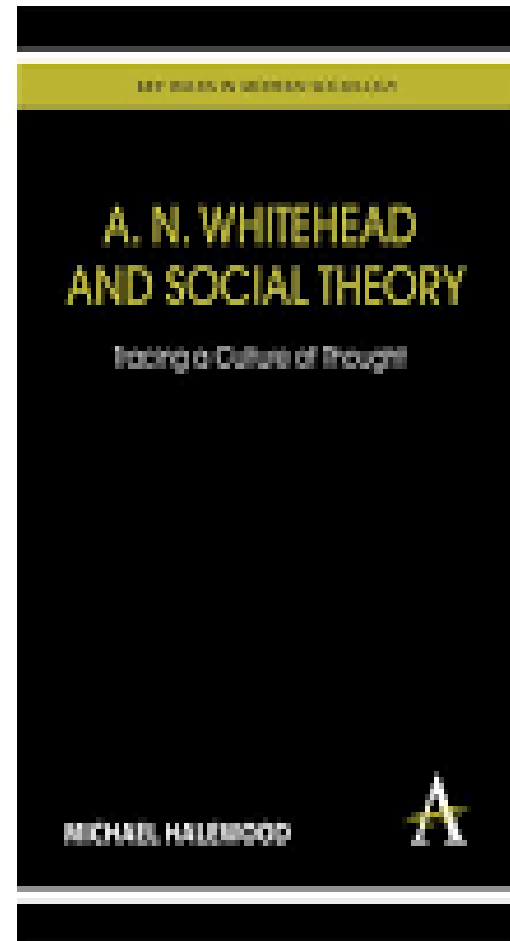
Once such splits are made, a gulf is created.

‘The worst of a gulf is, that it is very difficult to know what is happening of the further side of it’
(Whitehead, 1933: 217).



Bifurcation as the cornerstone of modernity?

- In my first book, I developed a theory:
- That modernity was based on a range of bifurcations



My view/argument/theory...

- ...is that this notion of bifurcation applies to a whole range of ideas in modern thought. And it means that we think badly about certain issues, such as:
 - Fact and Value
 - Public and Private
 - “Sex” and gender
 - “Race” and ethnicity
 - Language and the World
 - Science and Humanities

The End/The Start...